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Draft translation - not yet human-reviewed / مسوده ترجمه

Topic 4.1 - Attention and perception

A real classroom situation

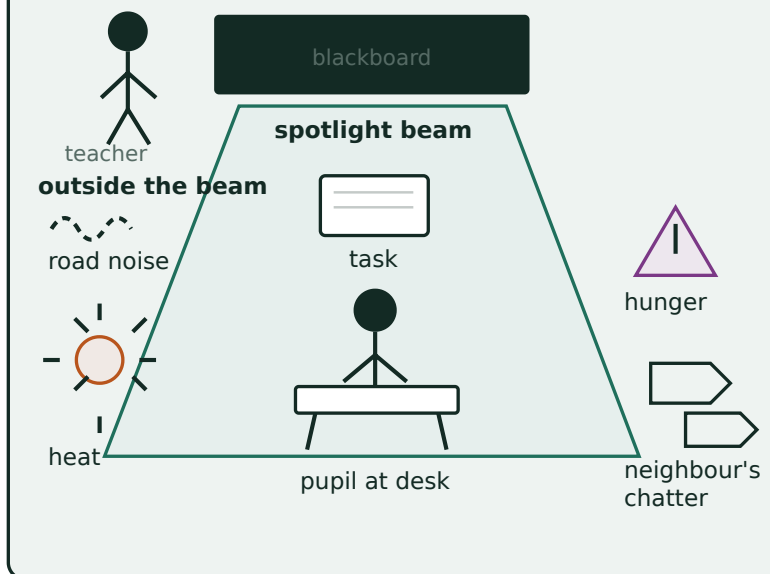
Miss Hina's Class 5 room in Nawabshah sits on the main road. By eleven o'clock the traffic is steady: rickshaws, a wedding band practising somewhere, the vegetable seller's call. She has sixty pupils and one blackboard. Her colleague in the quiet annex teaches the same lesson to the same syllabus, and her results are better, and the staff room explains this with "better pupils".

Miss Hina tried one thing. She moved the reading lesson to the first period, before the road woke up, and used the noisy period for copying and drawing. The reading marks moved first, and the class did not.

No pupil in that room lacks attention. What they have is a gateway that the road is competing for, at a time of day the road usually wins.

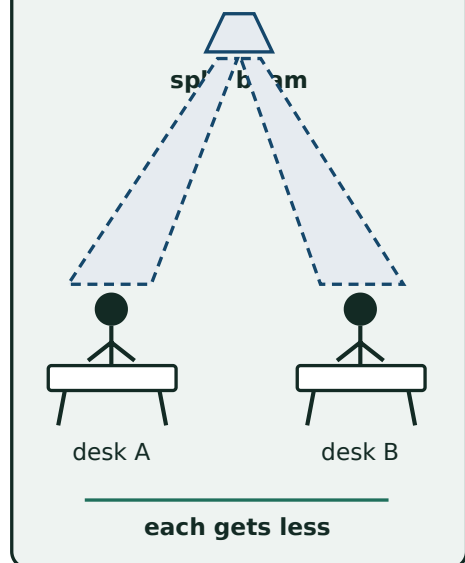
Focused attention: one target

The spotlight selects task and pupil.



Divided attention

One beam split between two targets.



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Explanation

Attention: the gateway to learning

Attention is the mind's selection: of all the information arriving at the senses at any moment, attention is what gets through. It is the gateway to learning because what is never attended is never encoded - the memory systems of Topic 4.2 receive only what attention lets past.

The most useful image is a **spotlight**. The beam is narrow: it lights one task, one voice, one problem at a time. Everything outside the beam still exists - the road, the heat, the neighbour's pencil - but it is not being processed for learning.

Three properties of the spotlight matter to a teacher.

It is captured, not commanded. Novelty, contrast, movement, meaning and emotion pull the beam; instructions to "pay attention" push it nowhere. A teacher competing with a wedding band for the beam by speaking louder is competing on the band's own terms - loudness. A teacher who writes the day's

question on the board before the band starts, or moves the hardest listening to the quiet hour, is competing on structure, which wins.

It divides only at a price. Divided attention - the split beam - gives each target less. The pupil who copies the board while listening to the explanation is running two tasks on one workbench, and the cost lands on the harder task. This is why "copy this while I explain" reliably produces notes without understanding: the copying wins the capacity and the explaining gets the remainder.

It tires. Attention is a resource that depletes with use, and it is shortest exactly where schools demand it most: in hot rooms, after lunch, in the last period. The evidence on inattention blindness makes the point uncomfortably: in the classic study, viewers counting basketball passes mostly failed to notice a person in a gorilla costume walking through the scene (Simons & Chabris, 1999, cited in Spielman, Jenkins & Lovett, 2020). A mind occupied is a mind with a closed gateway, and a Class 5 pupil occupied with the road may simply not hear the lesson.

The misconception to clear now. "Attention is a fixed quantity a pupil either has or lacks" - the "he cannot concentrate" verdict. Attention is a system with properties, not a trait with a size. The pupil who cannot concentrate for the double-period after lunch may concentrate beautifully for twenty minutes in the first period. The variable is the design of the demand, and the teacher owns most of the design.

Perception: how the mind interprets what the senses bring

The senses deliver sensations; the mind delivers the world. **Sensation** is detection by a receptor - light on the retina, sound on the ear. **Perception** is the organisation and interpretation of what was detected: "the way sensory information is organized, interpreted, and consciously experienced" (Spielman, Jenkins & Lovett, 2020). The eye receives light; the pupil sees the head teacher.

The classroom consequences of perception being *active* are easy to state and easy to forget.

What a pupil sees depends on what they already know. A Class 4 pupil who reads "قل" as one shape is not careless; the letters have not yet become, for them, the parts that a fluent reader perceives automatically. The same is true of every expert material: a chess board looks different to a player; a page of algebra looks different to a mathematician.

Ambiguous materials are perceived through expectation. A diagram a teacher has seen a hundred times is unambiguous to the teacher and a puzzle to the class. The teacher's perception hides the diagram's difficulty - which is why "it's obvious, look" is the least useful sentence in teaching.

Perception can be taught. What experts perceive quickly, novices can learn to perceive: letter shapes, number bonds, the structure of a graph. Teaching perception means arranging many encounters with the material, with the parts named, until the pupil's interpretation becomes automatic. That is one of the quiet jobs of practice.

what pulls or shapes it	in the classroom	one teacher move
Novelty a new object or voice	the unannounced demonstration jar	let the object do the announcing
Contrast difference against a background	the one coloured chalk line	use it for the single point that matters
Meaning relevance to the learner	the story that starts with the pupils' own street	open with what this is for
Emotion feeling attached to the event	the lesson about the flood they lived through	let the feeling carry the content
Task demand how hard the task grips	copying competes with listening	one demand at a time
Expectation what the perceiver already knows	the diagram obvious to the teacher	name the parts aloud before the puzzle

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Activity: The attention audit

In pairs, about 20 minutes.

Take one lesson you know well (your practicum class, or a lesson you remember being taught). Audit it against this topic in three passes.

1. **The beam.** What was the lesson's single most important demand on attention? How long did it run without a break?
2. **The competitors.** List every real competitor for the beam in that room, in the order a pupil would notice them.
3. **The split.** Find every moment the lesson demanded two attention-heavy tasks at once (copying while listening; writing while watching).

Then agree on the **one change** that would recover the most attention for the learning, and say whether it costs money.

Check your understanding

1. Define attention in one sentence, and say why it is the gateway rather than the workbench. (*Understand*)
2. Name three things that capture the beam, with a classroom instance of each. (*Remember*)
3. Explain why "copy this while I explain" produces notes without understanding, using divided attention. (*Apply*)
4. Distinguish sensation from perception with the blackboard example, in two sentences. (*Understand*)
5. The teacher says "it's obvious, look" at a diagram. Using perception, explain why the diagram is obvious to the teacher and a puzzle to the class, and name the remedy. (*Apply*)

Summary

Attention is the mind's spotlight: narrow, captured by novelty and meaning rather than commanded, costly to divide, and depletable - which makes it a design problem before it is a pupil problem. Perception is the active interpretation of what the senses deliver: what a pupil sees depends on what they already know, ambiguous materials are read through expectation, and expert perception is learned through named encounters. A lesson that works

with the gateway - one demand at a time, the beam aimed by structure, the parts of the material named - beats a louder lesson competing on loudness.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can define attention and describe the spotlight's three properties with classroom examples.
- ☐ I can explain the cost of divided attention and find it in a real lesson.
- ☐ I can distinguish sensation from perception and say why the teacher's perception hides a material's difficulty.
- ☐ I can name three attention factors and one teacher move for each.

Try this at your practicum school

Run one attention audit on your own lesson: the beam, the competitors, the split moments. Then make one structural change (timing, order, one-demand-at-a-time) and note what changes. Bring the before-and-after to the next session.

Summative task

Write **250-300 words** on Miss Hina's timetable move.

Her change - hardest listening to the first period, copying to the noisy hour - raised reading marks. Using attention's properties, explain exactly why it worked: which property the road was exploiting, what the move did to the competition, and what it cost. Then name one further change using a *different* property, and justify it.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
Property precision	The explanation names the specific attention properties at work, not "noise is bad".
Cost honesty	The trade-off of the timetable move is named. (<i>Analyze</i>)
Second move	The further change uses a different property and is realistic in her school.
Plain, accurate writing	Terms used correctly; no padding; within the word count.

Further reading

- Spielman, R., Jenkins, W., & Lovett, M. (2020). *Psychology 2e* (OpenStax), Sections 5.1 and 8.1. CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.
<https://openstax.org/books/psychology-2e/pages/5-1-sensation-versus-perception>
- Seifert, K., & Sutton, R. (2009). *Educational Psychology* (2nd ed.), Chapter 2. University of Manitoba. CC BY.
<https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/educational-psychology>

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